

Sheehan Quirke: The Cultural Tutor [C1]

Il suo scopo è rendere la cultura stimolante e alla portata di tutti. Per farlo, ha iniziato dalle reti sociali, grazie alle quali ha raggiunto migliaia di persone.

The Cultural Tutor is a modern success story. What began as a free website designed by British author Sheehan Quirke for cultural [tuition](#) soon grew into a social media phenomenon. When Quirke launched a Twitter account to attract people to his website, he never expected his posts to go viral. He now has more than 1.7 million followers, and has written a book that has gone on to sell thousands of copies worldwide.

BEGINNINGS

Before any of this success, author Sheehan Quirke made a [bold](#) decision: he quit his job in London in order to [pursue](#) more meaningful work. Hoping to teach young people about culture in a way that would make them more [well-rounded](#), he set up a free website offering cultural tutoring sessions for parents and their children. Quirke had spent much of his life reading widely and teaching himself about subjects he felt [compelled](#) to share, hoping others might find the same excitement and curiosity he did. To help people discover his website, Quirke started a Twitter account. He noticed that while [plenty of](#) people were writing about culture, very few did so in a way that worked in the [fast-paced, attention-driven](#) world of social media. Sheehan Quirke is a North East English influencer. Posting under the name The Cultural Tutor, Quirke has built a massive following (over 1.5 million). His daily [threads](#) reflect on art, architecture, history and literature.

GOING VIRAL

To [bridge that gap](#), Quirke borrowed the techniques of viral online posts and applied them to art, architecture, and poetry. He soon discovered that the most effective way to capture someone's attention was through storytelling built on contrast, often by placing two images side by side, such as an

older, [ornate](#) building next to a [stark](#) modern one. Very quickly, Quirke realised that people were responding to the short cultural reflections he posted online. Within just six weeks, his account had gained one hundred thousand followers. The sudden growth surprised him, but it also confirmed that his writing [resonated with](#) a much wider audience than he had originally imagined.

CULTURAL EDUCATION

Speak Up spoke to Sheehan Quirke to find out more about his journey from daily Twitter [threads](#) to writing a book. Quirke started posting a thread every single day, intending to do it for thirty days — an exercise that ended up lasting two and a half years. The daily ritual gave him a huge body of ideas, which he explored briefly online. When it came to writing his book, he was able to [draw on](#) that research, [arranging](#) the facts in a compelling way to tell a richer story. We started by asking him if he had always been exposed to culture, or whether it was a self-generated interest. **Sheehan Quirke (English accent):** There's a mix of both. I wouldn't say I'm from a particularly cultured family. I'm very lucky to have the family that I do, they're incredibly loving and wonderful, [clever](#), brilliant. I couldn't wish for better parents or a better family. But I didn't grow up going to the theatre, or going to the opera, or going to galleries. My dad... he often talks about how he's read two books in his life. One of them is mine, and the other one the book that Shackleton wrote about his journey to the South Pole. So, you know, my mum, she was... [she] made sure to put on listening tapes in the car. We'd listen to Greek myths and Egyptian myths and Arthurian myths in the car. So I did have that [grounding](#), which I think was really helpful. What really [fired my imagination](#) was to do with where I grew up, which is in rural Lincolnshire... there's not [an awful lot](#) to do. And throughout the countryside there, you've got all these medieval churches. And I had some friends, and [whenever](#) we met up, we would sort of just [wander around](#) the countryside and visit these churches. And there was something [remarkable](#) about when you're not that old, you're really just twelve or thirteen, and you [come across](#) this building in the middle of a field, and it's like a thousand years old, and you can just place your hands on the [stonework](#) that

someone carved a thousand years ago, and you go inside, and there's this wonderful [church], and it's mysterious. That got me interested in the history of churches and church architecture, and I started buying books and reading about them. And I found it really fun trying to figure out how old a church was based on the shape of its windows and particular kinds of design and decoration. And that's stayed with me ever since and I think that was a vital part of what got me interested in culture. Language

Algospeak, How Social Media Is Transforming The Future Of language
Linguista laureato ad Harvard, Adam Aleksic ha trovato il suo pubblico (ma anche il riconoscimento accademico) su TikTok. Dalla piattaforma documenta l'evoluzione dell'inglese ai tempi dell'algoritmo. Molly Malcolm

ACCESSIBLE STYLE

When Quirke launched The Cultural Tutor's Twitter account in 2022, his idea was to make culture more accessible to everyone. He explained to Speak Up how his deep belief is that culture isn't just for the elite, and that it's in fact embedded in everyday life. He considers that many activities, from football to video games or Lego, are art forms in their own right. **Sheehan Quirke:** Culture is a very loaded word and makes you think of old-fashioned stuff. And it's very fancy and sophisticated, but culture is for everybody. And look, I also loved video games as a child and as a teenager. And I loved football. I kind of realised football is culture too, and so are video games. I mean, I think video games are a new form of art. It's exciting, it's fascinating. And sure, not every video game is a masterpiece, but not every film is Andrei Tarkovsky's Andrei Rublev or whatever... Like, some films are just supposed to be easy watching. I used to love Lego as well. You imagine all these worlds and these characters. To get into culture, you don't just have to listen to Mozart as a ten-year-old, you can just be playing with Lego. And the key is demolishing those walls that people think separate these different avenues. And maybe that's one reason my work has done quite well, is that I am very happy to jump from Lego, or video games, to Xenophon, or Socrates, or to whatever... the 13th-century France.

NEW MEDIUMS

All of these early experiences did more than just [spark](#) Quirke's imagination. He learned to notice the details and connect ideas, appreciating that culture isn't just museums or opera; it's in everyday life. This perspective guides his approach to writing and sharing ideas: his unique style makes culture [engaging](#) and accessible. Since publishing his book, he is starting to explore new mediums to engage with his audience, such as YouTube.

Sheehan Quirke: When people ask me what I do, I sort of [mumble](#), "Oh, well, I write" or "I'm a writer", or something, which is very strange because it's like a dream come true. It's my [lifelong](#) dream. But to me, you're a writer if you write anything. [There's every chance](#) that my book, no one's talking about it in five years, ten years, and it doesn't really have the impact I hoped it would. That could very easily happen. [Other than](#) selling this current book, I'd love to write another one. And a few more after that. This is my [statement](#), this is my manifesto in a way for what I want to do [moving forward](#). And recently I released a video on YouTube. I worked with a good friend of mine, we got together a team that spent a lot of time and effort and money making a video related to the [topics](#) I've been writing about. And we released it on YouTube, fifteen minutes long, and it went really, really well. It went better than we could have hoped. It's about historical design and architecture and kind of looking at why things have changed. And this weird problem we have in the 21st century, where people don't really like the things that are being built. And this video, within a week, it had a million views, now it has two and a half million views.

Sheehan Quirke and his book The Cultural Tutor.

PAYING ATTENTION

Quirke went on to talk about their approach to the video. Instead of producing some speedy content, they decided to make it like films were made before, with the idea of retaining people's attention. He realised that

people actually responded well to this and hadn't lost their ability to concentrate. He also spoke about future projects, with the desire to make a series about architecture and art through the ages. **Sheehan Quirke:** We all know that the internet is getting sloppier than ever. The internet is just full of nonsense and AI has made this so much worse. Like I recognise its usefulness as a tool in certain scenarios. All it is, is a shortcut, not a substitute, and shortcuts are rarely good things. In the video we really tried to take an approach which evoked a slightly lost era. We slowed it down, we treated it like cinema. We wanted to respect our audience's attention. The internet is a Wild West, where people are fighting for attention, and we had this conviction that if we respected people's attention and respected them, then they would respond well. And it turns out people's attention spans haven't been destroyed at all. People can sit and watch something through if it's made to be watched. But I would love to make a show primarily about architecture and arts throughout history and what we can learn from that about life in the modern world. That's what I'd love to do, to work in a new medium. I want it to be kind of a rallying cry for this emerging issue. It's one that has been politicised, and I think we lose out when we politicise art and architecture. Because the beautiful thing about, especially architecture, is the better architecture is, the better everyone's lives are, especially ordinary people. The better houses are, and schools, and bus stops, and bins, and lampposts, which are my favourite things — I'm obsessed with these little details of our streets — the better they are, the happier everyone is.

STRONG FEELINGS

As his work continues to evolve — from daily threads to books, videos and future projects — Quirke finds himself reflecting not just on culture, but on the world his audience is growing up in. With so much of his success coming from the internet, he has strong feelings about the challenges it presents, especially for younger generations. That reflection naturally leads to a broader question: what does he make of the future, and of the young people engaging with his work today? **Sheehan Quirke:** Sometimes a particular generation gets unlucky. The flux of history, of technology and politics and culture condenses around a fulcrum at a particular point in time, and that

generation is just... they're unlucky. If I'd been born in 1897, I would have been in the [trenches](#) with my [schoolmates](#). And that generation was unlucky. They had to fight the First World War, and so many of them died all around the world. Part of me thinks that the current generation growing up with the internet as it currently stands is a little bit unlucky. They just came in at a particular point in time, the internet has reached this weird stage of absolute ubiquity, but it's not yet regulated. We don't yet understand it properly, and to some extent, they just have to [deal with](#) those consequences, which is quite a tragedy, but I don't think we can [pretend otherwise](#). And what history teaches you is that human beings have an unbelievable capacity for regeneration and recovery. We, as a species, have [lived through](#) the most unthinkable horrors and terrors, far worse than the internet, and we've [overcome](#) them [time and time again](#), and often, while overcoming them, are very happy to make jokes about it and laugh along the way. And I have deep faith in the human capacity for [correcting course](#), and I think that will happen with the internet. Things will never quite be the same again. Things were never be the same again after the [printing press](#) was invented, after [gunpowder came along](#), after electricity [came along](#), after nuclear power and nuclear weapons [came along](#). But we haven't [blown ourselves up](#) yet with nuclear weapons, and we're doing a pretty good job. For sure, there's work to be done, but there's always work to be done. And we'll still keep making jokes and falling in love and [having heartbreak](#) and making friends and losing friends. It never changes. www.culturaltutor.com

Glossary

- **attention-driven** = basato sull'attenzione
- **come across** = imbattersi in
- **loaded word** = parola grossa, pesante
- **it turns out** = risulta che
- **came along** = comparire
- **There's every chance** = è molto probabile
- **sloppier** = più approssimativo
- **bins** = cassonetti, cestini
- **remarkable** = straordinario
- **well-rounded** = completi, a tutto tondo
- **plenty of** = un gran numero di
- **bridge that gap** = colmare il divario
- **grounding** = base
- **trenches** = trincee
- **fancy** = elegante, raffinata
- **rallying cry** = grido di battaglia
- **fired my imagination** = ispirare
- **carved** = intagliare, scolpire
- **old-fashioned stuff** = cose antiche
- **has strong feelings** = avere forti convinzioni
- **time and time again** = più e più volte
- **gunpowder** = polvere da sparo
- **fast-paced** = frenetico, rapido
- **clever** = intelligente
- **wander around** = passeggiare
- **statement** = dichiarazione d'intenti
- **pretend otherwise** = fingere il contrario
- **printing press** = stampa
- **threads** = messaggi, conversazioni (lett. fili)
- **shortcut** = scorciatoia
- **slightly** = leggermente
- **lose out** = rimetterci
- **spark** = stimolare, suscitare

- **watch something through** = guardare fino alla fine
- **draw on** = attingere da, basarsi su
- **arranging** = organizzare, ordinare
- **engaging** = coinvolgente
- **schoolmates** = compagni di scuola
- **overcome** = superare
- **correcting course** = correggere la rotta
- **lifelong** = di una vita
- **fulcrum** = fulcro
- **flux** = flusso incessante
- **embedded** = integrare
- **pursue** = dedicarsi a
- **compelled** = in dovere di
- **deal with** = gestire
- **moving forward** = d'ora in avanti
- **lampposts** = lampioni
- **blown ourselves up** = farsi esplodere
- **tuition** = insegnamento
- **bold** = coraggiosa
- **ornate** = decorato
- **resonated with** = entrare in sintonia con
- **stonework** = muratura in pietra, opera in pietra
- **attention spans** = soglia di attenzione
- **in their own right** = a pieno titolo
- **an awful lot** = moltissimo
- **whenever** = ogni volta che
- **lived through** = sopravvivere a
- **having heartbreak** = soffrire per amore
- **stark** = austero
- **mumble** = mormorare
- **Other than** = oltre a
- **topics** = temi
- **nonsense** = assurdità